

Gobbling gamers

A Canadian-Danish study has led to the conclusion that video games make a person eat more even when they are not hungry

Amazon's Kindle library

Amazon will launch the Kindle Library Lending service later this year which will allow U.S Kindle customers to borrow kindle books from participating libraries

INTERCHANGEABLE LENS COMPACTS

Olympus EPL-1

This is a micro four-thirds camera, meaning it has a slightly larger sensor than the compact cameras we've looked at earlier. It has a burly look that is both clean and smart. From the neat recessed power button on the top to the silver finished body, the EPL 1 looks nice, if a



Olympus EPL-1

bit squarish. There is a grip provided, though it's not very large and thus not very good. On the top is a dial that exudes solid feedback and an audible click, but it's too hard to operate with one thumb, this dial controls the shooting modes. The recessed flash has a 2-piece armature, and there's a slider switch that releases the flash from its cubbyhole. A nice large, video record button with delicately soft feedback sits on the rear in easy reach of your thumb. The controls on the rear are pretty well laid out and quite intuitive to use, even though we'd like a little more spacing between some buttons, as Canon has done – there's a lot of wasted space around the microphone port on the rear, probably done to prevent it picking up noise of your finger as buttons are used.

The LCD is smaller than what we're used to, but it is very clear, and has no lag. Also absent is the flickering seen on cheaper displays. The 14-42mm lens we received feels a bit cheaper than the camera body itself. The zoom ring is wide enough to be gripped properly, but it feels a little rough at times, unlike the super smooth mechanism on the Sony NEX-5.

The output from the EPL-1 is quite frankly stunning. Taken in perspective, it's no EOS 7D, but when compared to the other cameras here, it's easy to figure out why larger sensors are so revered. The final bit of detail that seemed to be lacking from all the other sensors is present here, and the EPL-1 produces the ridged texture

on the flowers where the fine weave of cloth used is visible even beneath the dye/paint. The highlighting on the paintbrush finally looks clean, even as the text is super legible. The slight plastic bumps on the surface of the artificial mango that was part of the test scene are visible, as the paper clips look clean and detailed even on the white portion of the cloth. Highlighting is also spot on and the output is quite neutral.

At ISO 800, the EPL-1 is showing the same output and detail levels that some of the cameras failed to produce at their base ISOs – commendable indeed. However, at ISO 1600, the output gets softer, with some fuzziness, and at ISO 3200, the EPL-1 starts to look like a regular camera. Still, there's a fair bit of headroom to be played with, and the message is clear – need to work with higher ISOs – use something with a larger sensor.

Sony NEX-5

The Sony NEX-5 is a very solidly built camera and the immediate in-hand feel is one of quality. The body feels extremely dense. Even the 18-55mm f3.5-5.6 lens we received features metal in the outer lens construction and feels really solid. The camera itself is quite slim other than the grip that is large (for such a slim camera) and feels quite substantial, despite the fact that it's no DSLR. The NEX-5 has a relatively large sensor for cameras of this size bracket, and it boasts of a 1.5x crop sensor, the same size of sensor as seen on the Nikon crop DSLRs, and at 14.2 megapixels, is probably the same sensor that Nikon features on the D3100.

There is a latch on the top that opens to reveal a port that accepts the modular flash. The display is large and it's needed, because Sony's menu system is mostly visual. This menu might seem cumbersome at first, but as time progresses, it's evident that Sony put a fair bit of thought into this rather radical looking and different menu. The rear dial along with 2 buttons that flank it are the only menu

controls you get and while most actions take a click longer than if you had dedicated keys, it works reasonably well. Many of the menu options are also newbie friendly, like the background de-focus tool that allows you to spin the rear dial and changes the depth-of-field by modifying the aperture. Or you can manually change the aperture without using the newbie friendly menu. Most of the menus are context sensitive, for example, in auto mode, you'll see helpful menus such as the one described above, whereas in manual mode, you will see numbers for aperture and shutter speed – this is a rather intuitive system that we appreciated, for it's as usable by first time users as by advanced users. The battery is a 1080 mAh unit. The LCD is quite crisp and doesn't lag at all, and the NEX-5 has a crisp sounding shutter that nevertheless clicks twice when taking one shot, a louder click followed by a softer sounding one.

The NEX-5 produces images that look noticeably better than the Olympus EPL-1. The blue mug that held the roses finally gives off specular highlights, revealing flaws on its surface, while the cloth texture of the roses is also clearly visible. The output isn't perfect, as the red on the apple is over-saturated, but this is more a sensor characteristic than a flaw and can be corrected. The first place where noise shows up is in specular highlights, such as chromed surfaces, but really, you need to watch for it. Even at ISO 800 the NEX-5 produces detail



Sony NEX 5

that all the cameras missed at base ISOs – really the sensor is shining here, and ISO 1600 is also surprisingly usable for up to 8x11-inch prints. We also suspect the tack-sharp lens is a major reason for the NEX-5 resolving such high detail.